



**“MOMENTUM”: Empowering a Generation – The Cornerstone and FERWAKA
project 2026 – 2031.**

**Karate and Culture for Youth: Drug Prevention, Community Engagement, Personal
Development, and the Promotion of Responsible Behaviors for a Resilient Rwanda.**

In this document (project manual), the masculine gender is used without any discrimination and solely for the purpose of simplifying the reading.

This document is the official work of The Cornerstone organization and FERWAKA. Any modification, reproduction, copying, paraphrasing, and/or unacknowledged referencing is strictly prohibited.

Contents

Executive Summary	5
General Introduction and Context.....	6
Socio-demographic Context of Rwanda	7
Demography: A Predominantly Young Population	9
Social Pathologies and Youth Vulnerability	10
Link Between Social Pathologies and the Proposed Solution (Karate and Culture)	12
Limitations of Existing Interventions	13
Key Data in Rwanda and Internationally	13
Use of Psychoactive Substances	14
The most consumed substances include:	14
Early Pregnancies.....	15
School Dropout and Unemployment.....	16
Mental Health.....	17
Key Concepts Related to Youth Development	18
Positive Youth Development (PYD).....	18
The Impact of Sports and Martial Arts	19
The Role of Culture in Youth Development	20
Problem Statement	21
Hypothesis and Assumptions	22
General Hypothesis.....	22
Specific Hypotheses	22
Key Assumptions.....	22
General and Specific Objectives	23
General Objective	23
Specific Objectives	23
Expected Results	23
Beneficiaries	24
Direct beneficiaries:.....	24
Indirect beneficiaries:	24
Duration of the Pilot Phase	24
Estimated Budget	24
Project Design and Implementation Strategy.....	25

Theoretical and Methodological Framework.....	25
Positive Youth Development (PYD):	25
Social Learning Theory (Bandura, 1977):	25
Ecological Systems Theory (Bronfenbrenner, 1979):	25
Strategic Approach.....	26
Sport and Discipline (Karate Program):.....	26
Cultural and Moral Education:.....	26
Community Mobilization and Parental Engagement:	26
Psychosocial Support and Life Skills Training:.....	26
Project Implementation Structure	27
The Cornerstone (Lead Organization):.....	27
FERWAKA (Technical Partner):	27
Local Authorities (District and Village Leaders):	27
Schools and Churches:.....	27
Parents’ Committees and Mentors:.....	27
Target Areas	27
Key Components and Activities	28
Component 1: Karate Training and Discipline Formation	28
Component 2: Cultural Revival and Identity Building.....	28
Component 3: Awareness, Family Engagement, and Community Dialogue	28
Component 4: Psychosocial and Life Skills Support	29
Implementation Timeline.....	29
Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E).....	29
Objectives of the M&E system.....	29
Key Indicators:	30
Communication and Visibility.....	30
Risk Analysis and Mitigation Strategies.....	31
Sustainability Plan	31
Expected Impact	31
Institutional Framework and Governance Structure	32
Institutional Framework.....	32
a) The Cornerstone (TC).....	32
b) FERWAKA (Rwanda Karate Federation).....	32
c) Local Government Authorities (District and Sector Levels).....	32

d) Community and Parents' Committees.....	33
e) Partner Schools and Churches	33
Project Governance Structure	33
1. Steering Committee (Strategic Level)	33
2. Coordination Unit (Operational Level)	33
3. Community Committees (Local Level)	34
Roles and Responsibilities of Key Stakeholders.....	34
Coordination Mechanisms	34
Legal and Ethical Compliance	35
Capacity Building and Training.....	35
Strategic Partnerships and Synergies	36
Gender and Inclusion Strategy.....	37
Sustainability and Exit Strategy.....	37
Expected Impact, Evaluation, and Recommendations.....	38
Expected Impact.....	38
1. Behavioral and Moral Impact	38
2. Psychosocial and Educational Impact	38
3. Community and Cultural Impact	38
4. Structural and Institutional Impact	38
Evaluation Framework.....	39
Indicators of Change.....	40
Key Lessons and Good Practices (Expected)	40
Anticipated Challenges	41
Sustainability and Scaling Prospects.....	41
Alignment with National and International Frameworks.....	42
Recommendations for Policy and Practice	42
For Government and Policymakers	42
For Civil Society and NGOs.....	42
For International Partners	43
Conclusion	43
Annexes	44
Annex 1: Logical Framework (Logframe Matrix).....	44
Annex 2: Key References	44

Executive Summary

Rwanda, a country with a predominantly young population over 60% of its citizens are under the age of 25 (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022) is facing a worrying resurgence in the abuse of psychoactive substances among its youth. This phenomenon threatens not only the physical and mental health of young people but also their academic success, social integration, and the nation's overall socio-economic development. High unemployment, the lack of structured activities, and growing psychosocial vulnerability exacerbate this problem. The project “Karate and Youth Engagement in Rwanda” aims to significantly reduce drug abuse among young people by combining karate practice, traditional cultural activities, and strong community mobilization.

This innovative program provides a structured and safe environment that develops discipline, self-confidence, and psychosocial skills while strengthening family and community bonds.

The specific objectives include organizing weekly karate sessions in several pilot villages, setting up holiday camps, training local mentors, and encouraging the active involvement of parents and local authorities. The methodology is based on a participatory and inclusive approach, ensuring close coordination with stakeholders. Monitoring and evaluation focus on realistic indicators such as participation, retention, and satisfaction among youth and families, while recognizing that measurable reductions in risky behaviors will occur over the medium to long term.

The estimated budget for the pilot phase is approximately USD 75,000, covering training, equipment, events, and coordination. This project aligns with the National Youth Strategy and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and aims to serve as a scalable model at the national level.

By investing in Rwandan youth through integrated sports and cultural activities, this project contributes to strengthening human capital, enhancing social cohesion, and ensuring sustainable prevention of social pathologies that hinder the nation's full potential.

General Introduction and Context

Rwanda, like many African countries, stands at a decisive crossroads in its socio-economic development, where youth occupy a central place. According to data from the 2022 national census, nearly 65% of the Rwandan population is under the age of 25 (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022). This dynamic demographic represents tremendous potential for the country's future, but it also poses a major challenge in terms of support, protection, and balanced development.

Indeed, this youth population is exposed to multiple, often interconnected social risks that can jeopardize not only their individual fulfillment but also the stability and prosperity of the nation. Among these risks, the abuse of psychoactive substances including drugs, alcohol, and tobacco stands out as a particularly concerning threat, capable of causing serious consequences for the physical and mental health of young people (Rwanda Biomedical Center, 2020). Added to this are phenomena such as early unwanted pregnancies, school dropouts, social marginalization, and the lack of structured activities to occupy children's and adolescents' free time.

These issues, which can collectively be grouped under the concept of "social pathologies," represent a complex set of disorders and deviant behaviors that threaten social cohesion and collective security (UNICEF, 2021). They call for a coordinated and innovative response, capable of simultaneously addressing vulnerability factors and providing positive alternatives for young people.

It is within this framework that the present project was conceived, aiming to create a structured engagement center for youth aged 5 to 18. The central axis of this center will be karate practice, a sport recognized for its educational and formative values, particularly discipline, respect, self-confidence, and self-control (UNESCO, 2021). Karate will be complemented by traditional cultural activities such as dance, oral storytelling (known as "imigani"), and ancestral games like "ibisakuzo." This holistic approach not only seeks to meaningfully occupy young people's free time especially during school holidays and weekends but also to strengthen social and community bonds.

Furthermore, strong involvement of parents and young adults from the villages is planned to ensure quality supervision, local ownership, and lasting impact. This community mobilization aligns with international recommendations for preventing youth-related social pathologies, which emphasize the importance of family support and community participation (World Health Organization, 2022).

By transforming leisure time into an opportunity for learning, cultural expression, and personal growth, this project aims to significantly reduce risky behaviors and foster a resilient, responsible youth fully engaged in building their future and that of Rwanda.

Socio-demographic Context of Rwanda

Rwanda, located in the heart of the Great Lakes region of East Africa, covers an area of approximately 26,338 km² and has a population of nearly 13 million people (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022). With one of the highest population densities on the continent, this landlocked country faces both structural challenges and unique opportunities for development. Its recent history, marked by the 1994 genocide, profoundly affected its social, economic, and cultural fabric. Yet, over the past three decades, Rwanda has embarked on an ambitious reconstruction process guided by Vision 2050 and other national strategic plans that place youth at the center of the nation's future (Government of Rwanda, 2020).

The most striking feature of this demographic context is the youthfulness of the population: more than 60% of Rwandans are under 25 years old (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022). This youth population represents both an enormous economic and social potential and a significant vulnerability. High youth unemployment limited professional opportunities, and restricted access to structured recreational activities are aggravating factors that weaken this generation (World Bank, 2021). In many rural areas, the absence of suitable infrastructure and the scarcity of supervised recreational spaces intensify idleness and social exclusion conditions often linked to increased drug and alcohol abuse (UNICEF, 2021).

Despite these challenges, Rwanda has several favorable assets for implementing innovative prevention and development projects. Political stability and relatively strong governance create an enabling environment for community initiatives. Moreover, the country's cultural values and strong social mobilization expressed through youth associations, local structures, and

collective traditions serve as powerful levers for reinforcing social cohesion and local ownership of projects.

These dynamics can be leveraged to promote youth-centered interventions anchored in the cultural context.

It is in this framework that the initiative to combat youth drug abuse through karate practice is situated. Beyond its physical dimension, karate embodies values of discipline, respect, self-control, and perseverance (FERWAKA, 2024). By integrating local cultural activities such as traditional dances, storytelling, and games, the project proposes a comprehensive approach that addresses both the psychosocial needs of youth and community aspirations.

The goal is to transform free time often perceived as a vulnerability space into an opportunity for personal and collective development.

However, the success of such a project requires careful consideration of existing constraints. The country's landlocked geography complicates the distribution of resources and access to sports equipment, particularly in remote rural areas. Likewise, the psychosocial consequences of the genocide continue to affect family and community dynamics, necessitating sensitive and inclusive approaches to encourage youth participation.

To overcome these limitations, the initiative adopts a progressive strategy: **starting with a pilot project in a village such as Beninka, strengthening local capacity, then expanding the model to districts and, ultimately, to the entire country (The Cornerstone & FERWAKA, 2025).**

Thus, while the socio-demographic context of Rwanda is demanding, it provides fertile ground for innovative and sustainable solutions. By capitalizing on the potential of its youth and integrating sports, culture, and community engagement, this project aims not only to reduce drug abuse but also to build a more resilient and visionary generation capable of carrying the nation toward its long-term development ambitions.

Demography: A Predominantly Young Population

Rwanda, a landlocked country in the Great Lakes region, covers an area of approximately 26,338 km² and has nearly 13 million inhabitants as of 2023 (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022). The nation, marked by the tragic history of the 1994 genocide, has for the past three decades undertaken a rapid process of reconstruction guided by a strategic vision focused on resilience, innovation, and human development. At the heart of this vision lies its youth viewed both as a driver of transformation and as a population requiring targeted investments to unlock its full potential.

The demographic structure of Rwanda is dominated by its youth: more than 60% of the population is under the age of 25 (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022). This reality represents a dual challenge. On the one hand, it constitutes a considerable asset for socio-economic development, providing an abundant, creative, and adaptable workforce. On the other hand, it poses immense challenges in education, vocational training, employment, health, and civic participation. The Ministry of Youth and Culture (MINISPOC, 2023) describes this situation as a “demographic time bomb” without appropriate policies, this energy could transform into a source of social and economic tension.

The constraints are multiple. Youth unemployment remains one of the most pressing issues, with a rate estimated at over 20% (World Bank, 2021). This unemployment partly results from the education system’s difficulty in meeting labor market needs and from limited access to formal economic opportunities. At the same time, the lack of structured activities and supervised leisure leaves a large portion of children and adolescents in idleness a fertile ground for the emergence of social pathologies such as drug and alcohol consumption, violence, early pregnancies, and school dropout (UNICEF, 2021; MINISPOC, 2023). These phenomena threaten the country’s human capital and undermine development efforts.

Yet, Rwanda also benefits from a major cultural advantage: a rich heritage of values and traditions that reinforce social cohesion and could serve as levers to counter these risks. **Concepts such as “Ubumwe” (unity), “Ubupfura” (integrity), and “Gukorera hamwe”** (collective work) shape Rwandan identity and promote community solidarity. Cultural practices traditional dances, storytelling, and group games play a key role in transmitting these values, but they are increasingly inaccessible to younger generations, especially in urban areas.

It is within this context that the project “Combating Youth Drug Abuse in Rwanda through Karate” was developed. By integrating a sport that embodies discipline, respect, and self-control with cultural activities rooted in Rwandan identity, the project aims to provide young people with a structured space to channel their energy, develop resilience, and strengthen their sense of belonging. Thus, karate becomes more than a sport it becomes a tool for prevention and social transformation, aligned with Rwandan values and national aspirations.

Social Pathologies and Youth Vulnerability

Rwandan youth today face a range of social challenges that hinder their personal development and their central role in building the nation’s human capital. Among these challenges, social pathologies occupy an alarming place. They encompass behaviors and conditions that affect individuals’ physical and mental health, disrupt social cohesion, and impede economic development. Among young people, these pathologies are primarily manifested through substance abuse, early pregnancies, violence, school dropout, and increasingly, psychological disorders linked to stress and social isolation.

Drug, alcohol, and tobacco abuse is rising sharply in Rwanda, affecting not only urban areas but also rural settings, where social control mechanisms and support structures are weaker (Rwanda Biomedical Center, 2020). This situation stems from several factors: increasing availability of substances, peer influence, lack of structured activities, and the absence of positive role models in certain family environments.

The substances most used by Rwandan youth include cannabis, locally grown marijuana known as “urumogi,” and homemade fermented beverages (RBC, 2020). This phenomenon is not limited to major cities like Kigali or Huye it also affects rural areas where young people, lacking opportunities, turn to risky behaviors.

The consequences of this consumption are multiple: **physical health deterioration, mental disorders, poor academic performance, school dropout, and criminal behavior.** Over time, substance abuse leads to marginalization and social exclusion, perpetuating a vicious cycle of poverty and deviance. According to the World Health Organization (WHO, 2022), harmful drug use among young people is a major determinant of non-communicable diseases and mental morbidity in low- and middle-income countries.

School dropout is another structural challenge, often linked to economic pressure, lack of interest in education, or negative external influences. Early pregnancies play a major role in this issue: around 15% of Rwandan adolescent girls have experienced an unwanted pregnancy (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, 2022). These situations not only disrupt the educational path of young girls but also exacerbate gender inequalities, limiting their employment prospects and economic autonomy.

Juvenile violence, delinquent behaviors, and psychosocial disturbances are also recurrent symptoms. They often originate in idleness, family tension, frustration related to unemployment, and peer influence. The lack of access to structured educational and recreational activities promotes the formation of “street groups,” exposing young people to deviant models of success based on rule-breaking and rebellion. According to UNICEF (2021), adolescents who are out of school or disconnected from their families are the most at risk, as they seek identity and recognition in contexts with limited positive alternatives.

Mental health disorders constitute a critical yet often neglected dimension. Stress, depression, and unresolved trauma sometimes linked to domestic violence or intergenerational memories of the genocide exacerbate youth vulnerability. Without proper psychological support, these situations can lead to self-destructive behaviors, including drug use as a coping mechanism. WHO (2014) emphasizes the need to address these issues through an integrated public health approach.

Conceptually, social pathologies can be defined as disorders that disrupt the harmonious functioning of society, leading to behaviors contrary to public health and shared norms. Émile Durkheim (1897) viewed deviance as a symptom of weakened social bonds and moral disintegration highlighting the importance of initiatives aimed at strengthening community cohesion and shared values. In Rwanda’s post-genocide context, where reconstruction is based on principles such as unity and solidarity, these pathologies directly threaten the fabric of society.

These challenges demand a proactive, innovative, and multisectoral approach. Economic growth alone cannot address the root causes of social pathologies. Targeted interventions are required to simultaneously act on several levers: prevention of risky behaviors, school reintegration, creation of healthy leisure spaces, community awareness, and psychological care.

The Government of Rwanda, through Vision 2050, has emphasized that sustainable national development depends on cultivating an educated, disciplined, and resilient youth (Government of Rwanda, 2020). Investing in structured programs that address these needs is thus both a social priority and a strategic necessity.

[Link Between Social Pathologies and the Proposed Solution \(Karate and Culture\)](#)

In addressing these social pathologies, the main challenge is not merely to suppress risky behaviors but to offer young people meaningful and empowering alternatives. This is where the integration of karate, alongside Rwandan cultural activities, finds its full significance.

Karate, as a martial art, transcends its physical component. It instills discipline, self-control, respect for others, and resilience. Studies conducted in other countries (Weinberg & Gould, 2019) demonstrate that martial arts help shape youth character, reduce aggressive behaviors, and strengthen self-esteem. Applied to the Rwandan context, karate can channel young people's energy while providing them with a sense of belonging to a positive group.

Simultaneously, the integration of **Rwandan cultural values such as “ubumuntu” (humanity), “ubupfura” (integrity), and “ubworoherane n’ubufatanye” (solidarity)** anchors the project within local realities. **Traditional dances, storytelling (“imigani”), and group games (“ibisakuzo”)** are not merely recreational activities; they transmit intergenerational narratives rich in moral and identity-based lessons (MINISPOC, 2023). By combining sport and culture, the project builds an environment that empowers youth while strengthening community cohesion.

Thus, combating social pathologies is not only about “avoiding wrongdoing” but about making good attractive a logic that, as Albert Bandura (1977) theorized, fosters social learning through observation and imitation of positive models.

Limitations of Existing Interventions

Despite notable efforts by the government and NGOs, several limitations persist in combating these pathologies:

- Awareness programs are often focused on information dissemination (posters, media campaigns) but fail to provide consistent, engaging activities that occupy youth constructively.
- Sports and cultural infrastructures remain concentrated in urban centers, leaving rural areas with few alternatives (UNICEF, 2021).
- Existing community initiatives sometimes lack coordination, diluting their impact and hindering effective beneficiary follow-up (RBC, 2020).
- Psychological care and rehabilitation for youth already affected by social pathologies remain limited due to a shortage of specialized human resources (WHO, 2022).

These limitations underscore the need for a holistic project that combines:

1. a structured and appealing activity framework,
2. strong community ownership,
3. rigorous monitoring with measurable indicators,
4. and integration of local values to ensure program sustainability and acceptance.

Key Data in Rwanda and Internationally

To fully understand the scope of the problem and justify a structured intervention, it is essential to analyze available data at the global, regional, and national levels. These data reveal not only the scale of social pathologies among young people but also the specific dynamics that fuel them. The abuse of psychoactive substances, early pregnancies, school dropout, and psychosocial disorders are not isolated phenomena; they are interconnected trends shaped by economic pressures, cultural influences, and structural vulnerabilities.

This section first examines the use of psychoactive substances, one of the most visible and destructive forms of vulnerability among youth. The analysis, supported by international,

African, and Rwandan data, provides the foundation for understanding why innovative, integrated interventions such as those proposed by this project are crucial.

Use of Psychoactive Substances

The use of psychoactive substances today represents one of the most significant challenges to global public health and socio-economic development, particularly in countries with a high proportion of young people. According to the UNODC World Drug Report 2023, approximately 275 million people used drugs in 2022, and 36 million suffered from drug use disorders. This figure illustrates not only the magnitude of the problem but also its structural nature: it is no longer a marginal issue but a global reality requiring coordinated, multidimensional responses (UNODC, 2023).

In Africa, the situation is particularly concerning. Youth often described as the continent's "greatest resource" are also the most exposed. One in five people aged 15–24 uses psychoactive substances (UNODC, 2023). This trend can be attributed to several factors: rapid urbanization, high unemployment, lack of recreational infrastructure, and increased cross-border drug trafficking. Research also highlights the growing influence of globalized cultural models, where substance use is often normalized or glamorized by media and urban subcultures (WHO, 2022).

In Rwanda, the data confirm the emergence of a silent crisis. A survey conducted by the Rwanda Biomedical Center (RBC, 2020) found that 52% of drug users are aged between 18 and 35, precisely the age group expected to drive the country's socio-economic development.

The most consumed substances include:

- Cannabis, often linked to cognitive disorders and antisocial behaviors when used early;
- Alcohol, whose abuse is associated with domestic violence, traffic accidents, and decreased productivity;
- Tobacco, whose long-term health effects increase the economic burden on the healthcare system.

The analysis of these data reveals a fundamental contradiction: while Rwanda, through Vision 2050, aspires to build a prosperous and innovative society, a significant portion of its youth is being weakened by behaviors that undermine health, productivity, and contribution to the common good.

From a socio-economic perspective, psychoactive substance use imposes a triple cost:

1. Health cost: Chronic diseases and mental health disorders induced by substance use.
2. Social cost: Rising crime, violence, and school dropout.
3. Economic cost: Decline in productivity and diversion of resources from investment toward rehabilitation.

Beyond the numbers, this phenomenon reflects a deeper quest for meaning among young people torn between modern aspirations and a need for cultural grounding. Drug use is not merely an individual act; it is a collective symptom of structural misalignments loss of values, weakened community ties, and lack of engaging mechanisms to channel youth energy toward constructive projects.

This is precisely where the proposed project centered on karate and Rwandan cultural activities offers an innovative response. While the statistics highlight the problem's gravity, the integrated sport-and-culture approach provides an empowering alternative: spaces where youth energy and curiosity are positively harnessed. International studies show that regular participation in sports and cultural programs can reduce the likelihood of substance use by 30–40%, by strengthening self-discipline and the sense of belonging (UNESCO, 2021).

Early Pregnancies

In Rwanda, early pregnancies pose a major challenge to the health, education, and future of young girls. According to the Rwanda Biomedical Center (2021), about 7% of adolescent girls experience early pregnancy, leading to significant drops in school attendance and increased maternal mortality risks (UNICEF, 2022). These early pregnancies not only undermine young girls' well-being but also strain families and communities, perpetuating cycles of poverty and marginalization.

In some rural communities, economic hardship drives young girls into early unions or transactional relationships as survival strategies or family support mechanisms (RBC, 2021). This socio-economic reality complicates prevention efforts, which must therefore integrate reproductive health, education, and economic development components.

UNICEF (2022) reports that early pregnancies have a substantial negative impact on adolescent education, often resulting in school dropout and diminished economic autonomy. The vulnerability of young girls in these contexts calls for targeted programs offering support and accompaniment.

In response, public policies and social programs in Rwanda have increasingly adopted a multisectoral approach, aiming to provide adolescent girls with access to education, reproductive health services, and socio-economic empowerment, particularly in rural areas where risks are highest.

The present project aligns with this approach by incorporating educational and awareness activities on reproductive health, while mobilizing rural communities to create an environment conducive to prevention and the holistic development of young girls.

School Dropout and Unemployment

School dropout and unemployment are central challenges in Rwanda's socio-educational and economic landscape, particularly in rural regions. The Rwanda Education Sector Report (2021) indicates that around 20% of rural students leave school before completing the secondary cycle. This is often due to economic difficulties, inadequate educational infrastructure, or lack of family and community support. Dropping out severely limits young people's future prospects, restricting access to skilled employment and increasing vulnerability to risky behaviors.

The World Bank (2021) highlights youth unemployment as a key factor contributing to deviant behavior, violence, and social marginalization. The lack of economic opportunities pushes many young people toward informal, precarious activities or risky behaviors such as substance abuse. Unemployment also deepens feelings of exclusion and hopelessness, often leading to psychosocial distress and perpetuating poverty and delinquency cycles.

These two phenomena school dropout and unemployment are not merely symptoms of broader social problems; they also act as aggravating factors, reinforcing existing social pathologies within communities. Their interdependence underscores the need for a holistic, integrated approach in designing intervention projects that can sustainably address these risks.

Within this context, a targeted initiative like ours combining structured activities, alternative education, and skill development can play a pivotal role. By offering youth structured spaces for learning, discipline, and personal growth through karate and cultural activities, the project contributes to reducing dropout rates and improving social and professional integration prospects. Hence, integrating strategies that simultaneously address dropout, and unemployment is essential for ensuring the project's success and sustainability in preventing social risks in Rwanda.

Mental Health

Mental health is defined as a state of well-being in which an individual realizes their abilities, can cope with normal life stresses, work productively, and contribute to their community (World Health Organization, 2014). It encompasses emotional, psychological, and social balance, influencing how individuals think, feel, and act in response to life events.

Among youth, mental health is of particular importance, as this stage involves multiple physical, emotional, and social transitions. A healthy mental balance is essential for harmonious development, educational success, and social inclusion. Conversely, poor mental health exposes young people to heightened risks such as school dropout, substance abuse, marginalization, or even self-destructive behaviors.

According to Nsengiyumva et al. (2020), nearly 30% of Rwandan youth exhibit symptoms of anxiety or depression, revealing the magnitude of psychological distress in this demographic. WHO (2019) identifies youth mental health as a major issue requiring specific, context-sensitive interventions. The lack of adequate psychological and mental health services worsens youth vulnerability, negatively affecting both individual and collective well-being.

It is therefore essential to integrate mental health within a comprehensive approach to preventing social pathologies. These disorders should not be viewed in isolation but as factors interconnected with other social challenges school dropout, drug abuse, and social exclusion. A strategy that combines prevention, education, psychosocial support, and community involvement is necessary for an effective response.

Targeted programs must include mechanisms for screening, care, and follow-up that involve families, schools, and community structures. Such efforts strengthen youth resilience, improve quality of life, and mitigate the impacts of social pathologies.

Key Concepts Related to Youth Development

Positive Youth Development (PYD)

Positive Youth Development (PYD) is a theoretical and practical framework that promotes the holistic development of young people by focusing on their strengths and resources rather than solely on preventing risky behaviors. This approach emphasizes the creation of environments where youth can thrive, acquire life skills, and feel valued and supported by their social surroundings (Lerner et al., 2005).

The PYD recognizes that youth are active agents in their own growth and insists on providing structured opportunities that encourage social participation, leadership, and civic responsibility. It is a positive, proactive strategy that aims to strengthen resilience, self-confidence, belonging, and community engagement. The core idea is that when youth have access to supportive environments, they are less likely to develop problematic behaviors such as drug use, violence, or school disengagement.

In Rwanda, where a large youth population faces multiple social risks, the PYD framework is particularly relevant. It guides interventions that not only mitigate risks but actively foster social, emotional, and cognitive skill development through structured sports, cultural, and educational activities. The inclusion of karate in this project perfectly aligns with this logic: beyond physical benefits, karate teaches discipline, respect, self-mastery, and community spirit values that reinforce positive youth engagement (Vertonghen & Theeboom, 2010).

Promoting active youth engagement through well-designed programs is therefore an effective strategy for holistic development and a major lever for reducing deviant behaviors. Such programs must be inclusive, accessible, and culturally adapted to maximize impact. Involving families and communities is also essential to ensure coherence across youth environments.

Finally, positive engagement does not only mean participation in organized activities; it also implies developing a sense of self-efficacy and social belonging, powerful motivators of youth well-being and personal achievement (Catalano et al., 2004). Fostering these dimensions helps build a Rwandan youth that can confidently and responsibly face present and future challenges.

The Impact of Sports and Martial Arts

Sport plays a decisive role in youth development, not only by strengthening physical health but also by fostering personal growth, social integration, and civic engagement. Numerous studies confirm that structured participation in sports activities can significantly reduce the risk of deviant behavior, substance abuse, and school dropout (Bailey et al., 2013). When accompanied by adequate supervision, sport becomes a powerful vector for education, inclusion, and prevention.

Among the various forms of sport, martial arts hold a special place due to their holistic approach to physical, moral, and spiritual training. Beyond self-defense, martial arts are a school of life that teaches discipline, respect, perseverance, and self-control (Vertonghen & Theeboom, 2010). They cultivate not only the body but also the mind, fostering inner balance and social harmony. Karate, in particular, emphasizes courtesy, humility, and non-violence, making it an effective tool for both personal and social transformation.

In the Rwandan context, integrating martial arts into youth engagement programs offers several advantages:

- Physical and mental health improvement – Regular karate practice strengthens physical fitness and mental resilience, reducing stress and anxiety levels (Kim et al., 2015).
- Development of life skills – Karate promotes concentration, goal setting, perseverance, and conflict resolution skills.

- Social cohesion – Collective training builds mutual respect, teamwork, and solidarity across social backgrounds.
- Violence prevention – By teaching self-control and emotional regulation, karate reduces impulsive behaviors and violent tendencies.
- Empowerment and self-esteem – Achieving mastery and progress through ranks reinforces confidence and motivation.

The educational dimension of martial arts fits perfectly within the framework of positive youth development. It allows for transforming individual energy into disciplined effort, thereby channeling potentially destructive impulses toward self-improvement and community contribution. For young people exposed to frustration, unemployment, or family instability, martial arts provide a structured and secure environment that restores self-worth and purpose.

Empirical evidence supports this approach: research conducted by Lakes and Hoyt (2004) found that adolescents practicing martial arts displayed higher levels of emotional regulation, attention, and academic engagement compared to non-practitioners. Similarly, studies in post-conflict settings (Lee et al., 2019) demonstrated that martial arts programs foster trauma recovery, resilience, and social reintegration, particularly among vulnerable youth.

Thus, karate is not merely a sport but a vector of psychosocial development that aligns with Rwanda’s national priorities of promoting civic values, social cohesion, and human capital. By combining physical training with moral and spiritual education, karate becomes a multidimensional tool for prevention and empowerment.

The Role of Culture in Youth Development

Culture, understood as the set of values, beliefs, and practices that define a people’s identity, plays a central role in shaping youth behavior and social cohesion. In Rwanda, cultural heritage is both a moral compass and a foundation for collective belonging. Traditional practices such as “*umuganura*” (thanksgiving celebration), “*itorero*” (traditional education system), “*imigani*” (proverbs and storytelling), and “*indangagaciro*” (national values) have long served to educate, transmit virtues, and strengthen social bonds.

Unfortunately, these cultural mechanisms have gradually eroded due to urbanization, globalization, and the spread of foreign value systems. Many young Rwandans today are disconnected from their roots, adopting lifestyles that sometimes clash with traditional moral codes. This loss of cultural grounding contributes to the rise of risky behaviors, weakened social control, and increased youth identity confusion (MINISPOC, 2023).

Reintegrating culture into youth development strategies is therefore not a nostalgic return to the past but a strategic act of social reconstruction. It involves restoring cultural values as tools for education, discipline, and prevention. The combination of cultural and sports components such as karate practice accompanied by traditional dance, storytelling, or community gatherings creates a dynamic and identity-rich environment conducive to holistic development.

Culture provides meaning, while sport provides structure. Together, they shape balanced individuals who are physically strong, morally upright, and socially responsible. This synergy constitutes the foundation of the present project's philosophy: using culture and sport as complementary levers to rebuild the moral fabric of Rwandan youth.

According to UNESCO (2021), cultural and artistic activities strengthen self-esteem, creativity, and community belonging, while promoting mental health and social inclusion. In societies with a youthful demographic and rapid modernization, culture helps preserve identity and continuity. The project thus aligns with both national strategies for youth empowerment and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly Goal 3 (Good Health and Well-being), Goal 4 (Quality Education), and Goal 16 (Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions).

Problem Statement

The abuse of psychoactive substances among Rwandan youth has become a national concern, posing serious threats to health, education, and social stability. Despite government and community efforts, the prevalence of risky behaviors remains high, especially among young people aged 15 to 25. This alarming trend is fueled by unemployment, lack of structured activities, weakened family supervision, and loss of moral reference points.

The current prevention strategies, while valuable, remain largely reactive and fragmented. They focus on awareness and repression rather than providing concrete, positive alternatives

that can engage young people meaningfully. As a result, the gap between public discourse and real-life experience widens, particularly in rural areas where resources and infrastructure are limited.

This situation calls for an innovative, preventive, and community-based approach that leverages existing cultural and social assets. The challenge is not merely to reduce deviant behaviors but to transform the social environment that fosters them. The key question is therefore:

How can sport and culture be integrated to effectively combat the abuse of psychoactive substances and promote the holistic development of Rwandan youth?

Hypothesis and Assumptions

General Hypothesis

The combination of martial arts and Rwandan cultural activities constitutes an effective strategy for reducing risky behaviors among youth and strengthening social cohesion.

Specific Hypotheses

- Regular karate practice promotes discipline, self-control, and a sense of responsibility among participants.
- The integration of traditional cultural activities reinforces identity, moral values, and intergenerational dialogue.
- Community involvement ensures sustainability and ownership of the intervention.
- Youth engagement in structured, value-based activities reduces vulnerability to psychoactive substance use.

Key Assumptions

- Communities and local authorities are willing to participate in and support the program.
- Trained mentors are available to supervise youth activities.
- Adequate logistical and financial resources are mobilized to implement the project.

The collaboration between The Cornerstone, FERWAKA, and local structures ensures efficient coordination and monitoring.

General and Specific Objectives

General Objective

To contribute to the reduction of psychoactive substance abuse among Rwandan youth through karate practice and cultural engagement.

Specific Objectives

- To promote discipline, self-confidence, and psychosocial skills among youth through regular karate practice.
- To strengthen community cohesion and intergenerational exchange through cultural activities and local participation.
- To establish a pilot program in selected villages as a scalable model for national replication.
- To raise awareness among parents, schools, and local authorities about the importance of structured youth engagement.
- To monitor and evaluate the project's impact on youth behavior, school attendance, and community relations.

Expected Results

- Youth demonstrate improved discipline, respect, and social responsibility.
- Incidents of substance abuse among participants decrease significantly.
- Community solidarity and parental involvement in youth activities are strengthened.
- A functional, replicable model for youth engagement through sport and culture is established.

Local and national authorities recognize and support the program's contribution to public policy.

Beneficiaries

Direct beneficiaries:

Approximately 3000 children and adolescents (aged 5-18) participating in the pilot program across targeted villages.

Indirect beneficiaries:

Parents, families, schools, and local communities benefiting from improved youth behavior and strengthened social ties.

Duration of the Pilot Phase

The pilot phase will run for 12 months, divided into three stages:

- Preparation and mobilization (2 months) – recruitment, community sensitization, and logistical setup.
- Implementation (8 months) – regular karate sessions, cultural activities, and awareness campaigns.
- Evaluation and capitalization (2 months) – data collection, analysis, and recommendations for national scaling.

Estimated Budget

The total estimated budget for the pilot phase is USD 75,000, distributed as follows:

- Training and capacity building: USD 15,000
- Equipment and logistics: USD 20,000
- Cultural and educational activities: USD 10,000
- Community mobilization and communication: USD 8,000
- Monitoring, evaluation, and reporting: USD 12,000
- Coordination and administration: USD 10,000

Project Design and Implementation Strategy

The project “Karate and Youth Engagement in Rwanda” adopts a participatory, multidisciplinary, and inclusive approach. It aims not only to prevent deviant behaviors but also to promote the holistic development of young people by combining physical, psychological, moral, and cultural dimensions. The approach emphasizes empowerment and the creation of sustainable community mechanisms that foster continuity and ownership beyond the pilot phase.

Theoretical and Methodological Framework

The project is based on three complementary theoretical pillars:

Positive Youth Development (PYD):

This theory views youth as active agents of change rather than passive beneficiaries. It encourages the creation of environments that enhance strengths, resilience, and civic engagement (Lerner et al., 2005). Karate and cultural activities are structured within this framework to promote discipline, self-esteem, and belonging.

Social Learning Theory (Bandura, 1977):

Behavioral change occurs through observation, imitation, and reinforcement. By providing positive role models (coaches, mentors, peers), the program replaces deviant models with socially desirable behaviors, encouraging self-regulation and prosocial values.

Ecological Systems Theory (Bronfenbrenner, 1979):

Youth development is influenced by multiple interconnected systems, family, school, community, and society.

The project therefore operates simultaneously at different levels, fostering collaboration between households, schools, and local authorities.

This theoretical integration ensures that interventions are not limited to individual change but aim to transform the broader social and cultural ecosystem in which youth evolve.

Strategic Approach

The strategic design is built around four interconnected axes that mutually reinforce one another:

Sport and Discipline (Karate Program):

Structured karate sessions supervised by certified instructors from FERWAKA (Rwanda Karate Federation) aim to develop discipline, respect, self-control, and teamwork among participants. Training sessions will take place weekly, with group and individual evaluations to track progress.

Cultural and Moral Education:

Traditional Rwandan cultural activities storytelling (imigani), proverbs, music, and traditional games will be reintroduced to strengthen identity, values, and intergenerational communication.

These activities will be led by local elders and cultural leaders (abakuru b'imidugudu).

Community Mobilization and Parental Engagement:

Parents, local authorities, and community representatives will be actively involved in the program's design and monitoring. Community dialogues, workshops, and awareness sessions will ensure that prevention becomes a collective effort rather than an institutional imposition.

Psychosocial Support and Life Skills Training:

Trained mentors and social workers will provide psychosocial counseling, conflict management sessions, and life skills workshops. The goal is to prevent relapse, encourage self-expression, and equip youth with tools for emotional resilience and decision-making.

Project Implementation Structure

The implementation of the project will rely on a collaborative governance model involving several key actors:

The Cornerstone (Lead Organization):

Responsible for overall coordination, fundraising, stakeholder engagement, and reporting. The organization ensures compliance with project standards and oversees the communication strategy.

FERWAKA (Technical Partner):

Provides professional karate instructors, designs training curricula, and ensures technical quality control. FERWAKA also assists in youth selection and the monitoring of sports performance.

Local Authorities (District and Village Leaders):

Facilitate community mobilization, selection of beneficiaries, and integration of project activities into existing local youth programs.

Schools and Churches:

Serve as platforms for awareness and participant recruitment. They contribute to spreading the project's values and facilitating reintegration for school dropouts.

Parents' Committees and Mentors:

Ensure moral supervision, continuous monitoring, and feedback from families. They help create an intergenerational support network that sustains the project's long-term impact.

Target Areas

The pilot phase will initially focus on selected villages in the Eastern and Western Provinces, particularly areas with high rates of youth vulnerability as identified by district authorities and FERWAKA regional offices.

Priority will be given to:

- Communities with limited access to structured sports and cultural facilities;
- Areas affected by youth unemployment and drug use;
- Locations with active local leadership willing to participate.

After evaluation, the program will be scaled up to other districts and potentially replicated nationwide under the supervision of The Cornerstone and FERWAKA.

Key Components and Activities

Component 1: Karate Training and Discipline Formation

- Recruit and train qualified instructors (FERWAKA certified).
- Organize weekly karate sessions in target villages.
- Equip training spaces with basic gear (mats, uniforms, protective equipment).
- Conduct periodic competitions and demonstrations to promote motivation and visibility.

Develop a “Karate Values Manual” summarizing the moral and social lessons drawn from martial arts.

Component 2: Cultural Revival and Identity Building

- Host storytelling evenings (**imigani n’imivugo**) with local elders.
- Reintroduce traditional games (**ibisakuzo, urukiramende, igisoro,...**) to encourage teamwork and cognitive development.
- Conduct cultural dance workshops to promote pride and community bonding.
- Integrate educational themes such as respect, unity, and self-discipline into cultural sessions.

Component 3: Awareness, Family Engagement, and Community Dialogue

- Organize family workshops on parenting, communication, and youth mentoring.
- Hold monthly community meetings on prevention and values-based education.
- Collaborate with local radio stations to broadcast awareness messages.
- Establish “Community Youth Committees” to ensure sustainability and peer-led initiatives.

Component 4: Psychosocial and Life Skills Support

- Train mentors in basic psychosocial support and conflict management.
- Conduct group sessions on emotional regulation, leadership, and communication skills.
- Set up peer support groups for at-risk youth.
- Integrate mental health awareness into all program activities.

Implementation Timeline

Phase	Duration	Main Activities
Phase 1: Preparation	Months 1–2	Recruitment, training of instructors, logistics setup, community sensitization
Phase 2: Implementation	Months 3–10	Regular karate and cultural sessions, awareness campaigns, competitions
Phase 3: Evaluation	Months 11–12	Data collection, impact assessment, final reporting, scale-up recommendations

Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E)

A robust Monitoring and Evaluation framework will guide the project to ensure accountability, learning, and continuous improvement.

Objectives of the M&E system

- Measure progress toward objectives and results indicators.
- Track participation, retention, and satisfaction rates.
- Identify challenges and good practices for scaling up.
- Provide evidence-based reports to partners and donors.

Key Indicators:

Domain	Indicator	Target
Participation	Number of youth enrolled and active	≥ 300 participants
Behavior	Reduction in self-reported substance use	≥ 30% decrease
Psychosocial	Increase in self-esteem and discipline scores	+40% improvement
Community	Number of parents and leaders engaged	≥ 200 adults
Sustainability	Number of community structures created	≥ 5 committees

Data will be collected through surveys, attendance sheets, observation grids, interviews, and focus groups. The Cornerstone's M&E officer will compile monthly progress reports, validated by FERWAKA and local authorities.

Communication and Visibility

A targeted communication strategy will ensure the project's visibility and community ownership:

- Production of awareness materials (brochures, banners, posters).
- Local media engagement through radio and social media.
- Organization of public karate exhibitions and cultural festivals.
- Documentation of success stories through photography and short videos.
- Branding with logos of The Cornerstone, FERWAKA, and local partners.

This communication plan will strengthen recognition, motivate participants, and attract potential sponsors for expansion.

Risk Analysis and Mitigation Strategies

Potential Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation Strategy
Insufficient funding	Medium	Diversify donors and local contributions
Instructor unavailability	Low	Train local youth as assistant coaches
Community disengagement	Medium	Regular consultations and feedback mechanisms
Equipment damage or loss	Medium	Implement strict inventory management
Weather-related disruptions	Low	Use indoor venues or adjust schedules

By anticipating and managing risks proactively, the project ensures operational continuity and sustainability.

Sustainability Plan

Sustainability is central to the project's design. The following mechanisms will ensure continuity beyond the pilot phase:

- **Community Ownership:** Active participation of local committees in planning and monitoring.
- **Capacity Building:** Training youth as peer educators and assistant coaches for continuity.
- **Institutional Integration:** Collaboration with schools and local youth structures.
- **Partnership Development:** Long-term agreements with FERWAKA and The Cornerstone for expansion.
- **Resource Mobilization:** Development of income-generating activities (small local tournaments, cultural events).

Expected Impact

By the end of the pilot phase, the project expects to achieve the following transformations:

- Reduced drug use and delinquent behavior among youth in targeted areas.
- Increased sense of discipline, respect, and self-confidence.
- Strengthened family and community relationships.
- Revival of Rwandan cultural values among the younger generation.

- Establishment of a replicable model for youth engagement and prevention at the national level.

Institutional Framework and Governance Structure

The success and sustainability of the “Karate and Youth Engagement in Rwanda” project depend on a clear institutional framework, participatory governance, and transparent coordination among all partners. The project structure is designed to ensure efficient decision-making, accountability, and community ownership at every level.

Institutional Framework

The project will be implemented through a collaborative partnership between The Cornerstone (TC), FERWAKA (Rwanda Karate Federation), and local community structures (schools, youth committees, and administrative authorities).

Each partner has distinct yet complementary responsibilities that contribute to the coherence and success of the program.

a) The Cornerstone (TC)

- Acts as the lead institution and primary implementing agency.
- Ensures strategic direction, coordination, and financial management.
- Oversees project planning, documentation, and donor communication.
- Ensures adherence to ethical and accountability standards.
- Supervises monitoring and evaluation, reporting to stakeholders

b) FERWAKA (Rwanda Karate Federation)

- Serves as the technical partner in charge of martial arts implementation.
- Provides certified karate instructors, training materials, and quality control.
- Designs and validates the pedagogical framework for karate sessions.
- Evaluates participants’ technical progress and organizes examinations.

c) Local Government Authorities (District and Sector Levels)

- Facilitate local mobilization and official authorization of activities.
- Integrate the project into existing youth development and sports plans.
- Provide logistical support through community facilities and local networks.
- Participate in monitoring and ensure local accountability.

d) Community and Parents' Committees

- Support project implementation through local supervision.
- Encourage youth participation and family engagement.
- Provide feedback to coordinators on community needs and improvements.

e) Partner Schools and Churches

- Help identify and recruit youth beneficiaries.
- Promote moral and social education aligned with the project's values.
- Offer venues for sessions and workshops when available

Project Governance Structure

The governance model is organized into three levels to ensure efficiency and transparency:

1. Steering Committee (Strategic Level)

Composed of representatives from The Cornerstone, FERWAKA, local authorities, and community leaders.

Main responsibilities:

- Approve annual work plans and budgets.
- Provide strategic oversight and policy guidance.
- Review quarterly reports and ensure compliance with objectives.
- Facilitate coordination among partners.

2. Coordination Unit (Operational Level)

Located within The Cornerstone, this unit manages day-to-day activities.

Main responsibilities:

- Oversee implementation, logistics, and supervision.
- Maintain communication between stakeholders.
- Compile and analyze monitoring data.
- Prepare progress and financial reports.

Composition:

- Project Coordinator (The Cornerstone)
- Technical Director (FERWAKA)
- Monitoring & Evaluation Officer
- Administrative and Finance Officer
- Communication & Visibility Officer

3. Community Committees (Local Level)

Set up in each target village or sector, composed of youth representatives, parents, teachers, and local leaders.

Main responsibilities:

- Facilitate local mobilization and feedback.
- Ensure attendance, discipline, and mentoring of participants.
- Report to the Coordination Unit monthly.

Roles and Responsibilities of Key Stakeholders

Stakeholder Main Responsibilities:

The Cornerstone (TC)	Project leadership, coordination, fundraising, financial management, reporting
FERWAKA	Technical karate supervision, instructor training, certification
Local Authorities	Administrative facilitation, community mobilization, policy linkage
Parents' Committees	Support discipline and follow-up of participants
Schools/Churches	Youth recruitment, moral education, logistical support
Mentors & Volunteers	Psychosocial support, leadership training, follow-up
Donors/Partners	Financial and material contributions, evaluation collaboration

Coordination Mechanisms

Monthly Coordination Meetings:

- Bringing together TC, FERWAKA, and community representatives to review progress, challenges, and next steps.
- Quarterly Field Visits:
- Conducted jointly by TC and FERWAKA to assess quality, document good practices, and ensure accountability.

Communication Channels:

- Telephone, WhatsApp groups and email lists for continuous coordination between partners, instructors, and local leaders.

Reporting System:

- Standardized templates for activity reports, attendance, finances, and incidents, submitted monthly to the Coordination Unit.

Annual Review Workshop:

- Brings together all partners and stakeholders to share results, lessons learned, and strategic recommendations for scaling

Legal and Ethical Compliance

The project will operate under Rwandan laws governing non-profit organizations, youth protection, and sports federations.

All activities will comply with:

- National child protection standards (Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion – MIGEPROF).
- Ethical codes of conduct for instructors, volunteers, and staff.
- Policies on gender equality, inclusion, and non-discrimination.
- Data protection regulations for youth participants.
- A Child Protection Policy and Code of Ethics will be developed, requiring all staff and instructors to undergo orientation and sign compliance forms before engaging in activities.

Capacity Building and Training

To ensure sustainability and quality, the project includes a strong training component:

- Instructor Training: FERWAKA will conduct technical workshops to certify karate coaches according to international standards.
- Mentor Development: The Cornerstone will organize psychosocial support and leadership training for local mentors.
- Community Education: Parents and leaders will receive training in youth communication, child protection, and prevention of social pathologies.
- Administrative and M&E Training: Project staff will receive capacity building in documentation, reporting, and results-based management.

Training will be ongoing, combining theoretical modules, field practice, and peer learning sessions. The Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E) framework will follow international standards (UNDP Results-Based Management). It will include:

- **Baseline Study:** Conducted before implementation to assess the initial situation of participants and communities.
- **Mid-term Review:** Conducted after six months to measure progress and adjust activities.
- **Final Evaluation:** Conducted at the end of the 12-month period to assess results, effectiveness, and scalability potential.

Reports to be produced:

- Monthly activity reports
- Quarterly progress reports
- Annual final report
- Financial statements audited by an independent firm

Data collected will include both quantitative and qualitative indicators (attendance rates, testimonies, behavioral changes, etc.), ensuring a comprehensive analysis of impact.

Strategic Partnerships and Synergies

To optimize impact, the project will pursue partnerships with:

- **Ministry of Youth and Culture (MINISPOC)** – for policy alignment, youth engagement, and cultural development support.
- **Ministry of Health (MoH)** – for health promotion, mental health awareness, and substance abuse prevention programs.
- **Ministry of Education (MINEDUC)** – for integration of life skills, prevention education, and psychosocial support in schools.
- **Rwanda Biomedical Center (RBC)** – for technical input on drug prevention and national health campaigns.
- **UNICEF Rwanda** – for child protection, youth empowerment, and advocacy partnerships.

- **Local NGOs and Churches** – for community mobilization, counseling, and moral reinforcement.
- **Media Outlets** – for advocacy, visibility, and public awareness campaigns.

These partnerships will ensure complementarity, resource sharing, and increased legitimacy of the initiative at the national and international levels.

Gender and Inclusion Strategy

The project promotes gender equality and the inclusion of vulnerable youth, including children from low-income families, single-parent households, and those at risk of dropping out of school.

Key measures include:

- Ensuring at least 50% female participation.
- Providing uniforms and equipment free of charge for disadvantaged participants.
- Training instructors on gender sensitivity and child protection.
- Promoting mixed training sessions to foster equality and mutual respect.

By integrating gender and inclusion principles, the project contributes to building a fairer and more cohesive Rwandan society.

Sustainability and Exit Strategy

The project's sustainability relies on local empowerment, institutional integration, and gradual transfer of responsibility to community structures. The exit strategy includes:

- Strengthening local youth committees to manage activities independently.
- Incorporating karate clubs into school extracurricular programs.
- Training former participants as assistant instructors and mentors.
- Establishing partnerships with district sports departments for resource continuity.
- Developing a local fundraising mechanism (community events, sponsorships).

At the end of the pilot phase, a Sustainability Report will propose pathways for national expansion and institutionalization.

Expected Impact, Evaluation, and Recommendations

The “Karate and Youth Engagement in Rwanda” project is designed to bring both immediate and long-term transformations within the communities it serves. By combining physical discipline, cultural education, and psychosocial support, it aims to build a new generation of responsible, healthy, and engaged Rwandan youth.

This part presents the project’s anticipated impact, evaluation mechanisms, lessons learned, and strategic recommendations for scaling and sustainability.

Expected Impact

The project’s expected impact is both individual (behavioral and psychological transformation among youth) and collective (strengthening family and community resilience).

It can be summarized across four main dimensions:

1. Behavioral and Moral Impact

- Youth develop discipline, self-control, and respect through regular karate training.
- Reduced drug consumption and delinquent behavior among participants.
- Strengthened adherence to positive moral values inspired by Rwandan culture.

2. Psychosocial and Educational Impact

- Improved self-esteem and emotional stability among youth.
- Increased school attendance and reduced dropout rates.
- Improved family relationships through parent-child collaboration in project activities.

3. Community and Cultural Impact

- Revival and valorization of Rwandan traditions among younger generations.
- Strengthened intergenerational dialogue through shared cultural events.
- Greater community cohesion, with parents and leaders united in prevention efforts.

4. Structural and Institutional Impact

- Creation of local frameworks for youth engagement that can be replicated nationwide.
- Strengthened partnerships between civil society, sports institutions, and local authorities.
- Enhanced community leadership in prevention and social education.

Evaluation Framework

a) Evaluation Objectives

The evaluation aims to

- Measure the project's efficiency, effectiveness, and relevance.
- Assess behavioral and psychosocial changes among beneficiaries.
- Identify success factors and improvement areas.
- Provide evidence-based recommendations for future scaling.

b) Evaluation Methodology

The evaluation will use mixed methods combining quantitative and qualitative data collection tools:

- **Baseline Survey:** Conducted before the project begins to assess youth vulnerability, behaviors, and perceptions.
- **Mid-term Review:** Measures progress and identifies challenges.

Final Evaluation: Assesses achievement of objectives and long-term sustainability potential.

Tools used include:

- Questionnaires and focus groups
- Observation grids during karate and cultural sessions
- Interviews with parents, instructors, and local leaders
- Case studies and testimonials

Indicators of Change

Domain	Indicator	Measurement Tool
Behavior	Reduction in substance use	Pre- and post-intervention surveys
Education	Improvement in school attendance	Reports from schools and parents
Psychosocial	Increased self-esteem and discipline	Self-assessment scales and mentor observation
Community	Number of active parents and leaders	Attendance records and participation lists
Sustainability	Establishment of local karate clubs	Progress reports and follow-up evaluations

Each indicator will be tracked monthly and compiled in quarterly reports validated by **The Cornerstone** and **FERWAKA**.

Key Lessons and Good Practices (Expected)

Although implementation is still at the pilot stage, several good practices are expected to emerge:

- **Integrated Approach Works Best:** Combining sports, culture, and psychosocial support produces more lasting behavioral change than isolated interventions.
- **Community Ownership Is Essential:** The involvement of parents and local leaders ensures sustainability.
- **Mentorship Builds Continuity:** Training youth leaders as mentors fosters peer influence and long-term engagement.
- **Cultural Integration Strengthens Identity:** The reintroduction of local traditions restores moral references and belonging.
- **Gender Equality Promotes Social Balance:** Equal participation helps redefine gender norms positively within communities.

These insights will serve as guiding principles for the program's national expansion and adaptation to other contexts.

Anticipated Challenges

Despite strong community enthusiasm, certain challenges may arise during implementation:

- Limited resources for equipment and logistics.
- Varying levels of parental engagement in rural vs. urban areas.
- Socioeconomic barriers (poverty, transport costs).
- Need for continuous motivation among youth participants.

Possible stigmatization of former drug users in community reintegration.

Mitigation strategies include continuous communication, incentive mechanisms, and reinforcement of community solidarity.

Sustainability and Scaling Prospects

The pilot phase aims to establish a model of excellence that can be replicated across Rwanda.

The long-term plan includes:

- Institutionalization: Integrating karate and cultural programs into school curricula and youth centers.
- Expansion: Scaling to new districts based on pilot results.
- Partnership Consolidation: Strengthening collaboration with ministries, NGOs, and international donors.
- Local Leadership Development: Training young beneficiaries to become coaches, mentors, or cultural ambassadors.
- Economic Sustainability: Exploring income-generating opportunities through tournaments, events, and sponsorships.

The ultimate goal is to create a national network of community-based karate and cultural centers promoting holistic youth development.

Alignment with National and International Frameworks

The project directly contributes to several Rwandan and global strategic frameworks, including:

- Rwanda Vision 2050: Human capital development and social transformation.
- National Youth Policy (MINISPOC, 2023): Empowerment, civic responsibility, and participation.
- National Strategy for Child Rights (MIGEPROF): Child protection and youth development.
- UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs):
 - SDG 3: Good health and well-being.
 - SDG 4: Quality education.
 - SDG 5: Gender equality.
 - SDG 16: Peace, justice, and strong institutions.

This alignment ensures that the project not only addresses local needs but also contributes to Rwanda's international commitments in youth empowerment and sustainable development.

Recommendations for Policy and Practice

Based on the project's framework and anticipated outcomes, the following several strategic recommendations emerge:

For Government and Policymakers

- Institutionalize sport and cultural education as tools for social prevention.
- Strengthen funding mechanisms for youth-led community initiatives.
- Facilitate public-private partnerships supporting sports and cultural projects.
- Promote mental health awareness and services in schools.

For Civil Society and NGOs

- Encourage collaboration across sectors (health, education, culture, and sports).
- Develop networks of youth mentors trained in prevention and psychosocial support.
- Support the replication of integrated sport-culture programs in rural communities.
- For Local Authorities and Families
- Maintain active community involvement and moral guidance for youth.
- Organize family-oriented events to reinforce social ties.

- Recognize and celebrate youth achievements publicly to boost motivation.

For International Partners

- Provide technical and financial assistance for expansion.
- Support capacity-building and knowledge-sharing initiatives.
- Facilitate cross-country exchange programs for best practices.

Conclusion

The “Karate and Youth Engagement in Rwanda” project is more than a youth program it is a movement of social renewal rooted in Rwandan values and modern prevention strategies. By merging sport, culture, and community mobilization, it offers an innovative, realistic, and scalable solution to the pressing challenges facing Rwandan youth.

The project restores dignity and purpose to a generation seeking meaning, transforming vulnerability into strength, and chaos into discipline. It positions karate and culture not only as tools of physical development but as instruments of national transformation building a resilient, responsible, and visionary youth ready to carry Rwanda toward the aspirations of Vision 2050.

Annexes

Annex 1: Logical Framework (Logframe Matrix)

Objective Hierarchy	Indicators	Verification Means	Assumptions
General Objective: Reduce youth drug abuse through sport and culture	Decrease in substance use rates	Evaluation reports, surveys	Continued community engagement
Specific Objectives: Promote discipline, identity, and community engagement	Attendance rate, satisfaction levels	Training records, interviews	Consistent youth participation
Expected Results: Improved behavior and community cohesion	% increase in self-control, civic engagement	Mentor reports, M&E data	Effective mentorship program
Activities: Karate sessions, cultural workshops, awareness campaigns	Number of activities implemented	Monthly reports	Funding and logistical continuity

Annex 2: Key References

- Rwanda Biomedical Center (RBC), Drug Use and Youth Health Report, 2020.
- National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda (NISR), Population Census, 2022.
- World Health Organization (WHO), Youth Mental Health Framework, 2014–2022.
- United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), World Drug Report, 2023
- UNESCO, Sport and Youth Development Report, 2021.
- Government of Rwanda, Vision 2050 and National Youth Policy, 2023.
- The Cornerstone & FERWAKA, Project Development Framework, 2025.